

about AVG was that when e-mails were being sent and received, the program automatically brought up a bar that displayed what was going on: “mails being downloaded,” “no viruses found,” and other messages along those lines—very cool!

Installation was a breeze. The installer for the Free Edition automatically assigns you a registration number during installation. There’s a helpful post-installation screen that lets you configure the commonly-used aspects of the program. You are prompted straight-away to update your virus definitions.

Features are aplenty, while not being too confusing, just like avast! and all other good software. You can scan floppies, program files, documents, and e-mail files; you can choose to ‘use heuristic analysis’, enable ‘on-close scanning’, or even scan all files. You can choose to do a quick test—this is the ‘System Areas Test.’ The System Areas Test only scans important system areas, files and registry keys.

Double-clicking the icon on the system tray brings up everything at a glance: the resident shield, the e-mail scanner, the status of the internal virus database, etc. You can check for updates with one click. You can choose to have the program check for updates periodically—at intervals that you specify—and to scan your computer at periodic intervals. In the Pro (paid) version, you can also select what areas of the computer to scan at periodic intervals.

One thing about anti-virus programs is the way they seem to stick on and be out of your control! For example, in Norton AntiVirus, it’s not straightforward to shut down the program; the program seems to behave as though it knows better than you. In AVG, the Control Center and the app that scans disks are separate, as it should be. And unlike Norton, it’s easy to shut down the program—just two clicks!

So what’s not to like? About the only thing we found was that there are a couple of cryptic things in the menus. For example, under ‘Properties’ in the ‘Control Center’, you have the option to